

timing, things that were bought too early or held too long: the \$2,000 Apple computer in the former category, the art deco water pitchers in the latter. The old train set and the baseball cards thrown away long ago by mistake once had a sentimental value, but since prices of such items are now common knowledge, I now remember them as hundreds of dollars lost in the restructuring of my childhood closet.

A couch was once a place on which to sit, and a chest of drawers a place in which to put things, but these, too, have evolved into collectibles—and so the cat-claw marks, the jelly stains, the rips, the tears, the broken handles, the gouges in the record cabinet, the scratches in the marble table, the mildew spots on stuffed armchairs left outside in the rain are no longer simple repair jobs. They're threats to the bottom line, and a great deal more fuss is made over mishaps these days.

Our clothes are a continual source of fiscal disappointment, especially during the frequent catastrophes when they are soiled, ripped, or otherwise damaged. Having spaghetti dumped in one's lap is the dinner-party equivalent of a 30 percent drop in a stock or the cancellation of a dividend. The same can be said for high heels that are sheared off by a hidden sprinkler head.

Since clothes have become investments, many of the hand-me-down items that we once kept in paper bags for Halloween costumes or used as car rags are now hung in the closets. This includes old Pucci dresses and houndstooth coats too big in the shoulders, feather boas worn by relatives from café society, discarded kilts from Scottish festivals, Hawaiian shirts retained since college, scarves, trout vests, riding jodhpurs, and smocks made from Panamanian molas. Someday, we assure ourselves, there'll be a bull market in molas.

Have we just gotten greedy, or have we been forced into it: routed from our passbooks by fantastic opportunities; lured by the irresistible increases in the price of gold, silver, grandfather clocks; convinced that it is highly speculative not to speculate; millions of us and our loose cash, wandering from chance to chance, desperate for good advice yet almost always confused; our net worth vacillating with the monetary system, the fiscal system, the balance of trade; our futures papered in CATS funds and zero-coupon bonds;